

to investigate Kennedy's assassination was a strong political maneuver, designed to hold the lid firmly down on a dangerous issue.

In domestic affairs, Johnson committed himself even more firmly than Kennedy to the cause of civil rights. Johnson's utopian vision of the "Great Society"—upon which his 1964 election campaign was based—ushered in antipoverty and antidiscrimination programs, designed to defend America's least privileged citizens.

Vietnamese nightmare

Foreign affairs were not Johnson's forte. He had none of Kennedy's background in diplomacy or broad international outlook. Faced with the worsening crisis in Vietnam, Johnson was heavily dependent on advisers inherited from Kennedy's administration. More pugnacious than his predecessor, Johnson treated the North Vietnamese politburo like recalcitrant congressmen, who might be bullied or bribed into doing what he wished. Far from wanting a war in Vietnam, he loathed it as a distraction from his real concerns and a nightmare from which he could not escape.

By the end of his presidency, Johnson was a tragic figure. His vision of the Great Society had proved a mirage as a series of riots broke out in the streets and the cost of war undermined federal finances. His decision not to seek the Democratic nomination for a second term in 1968 was based on the knowledge that he could not have secured it. Johnson lived only four years after leaving office—he died one day before the signing of the peace deal that ended America's Vietnam War.